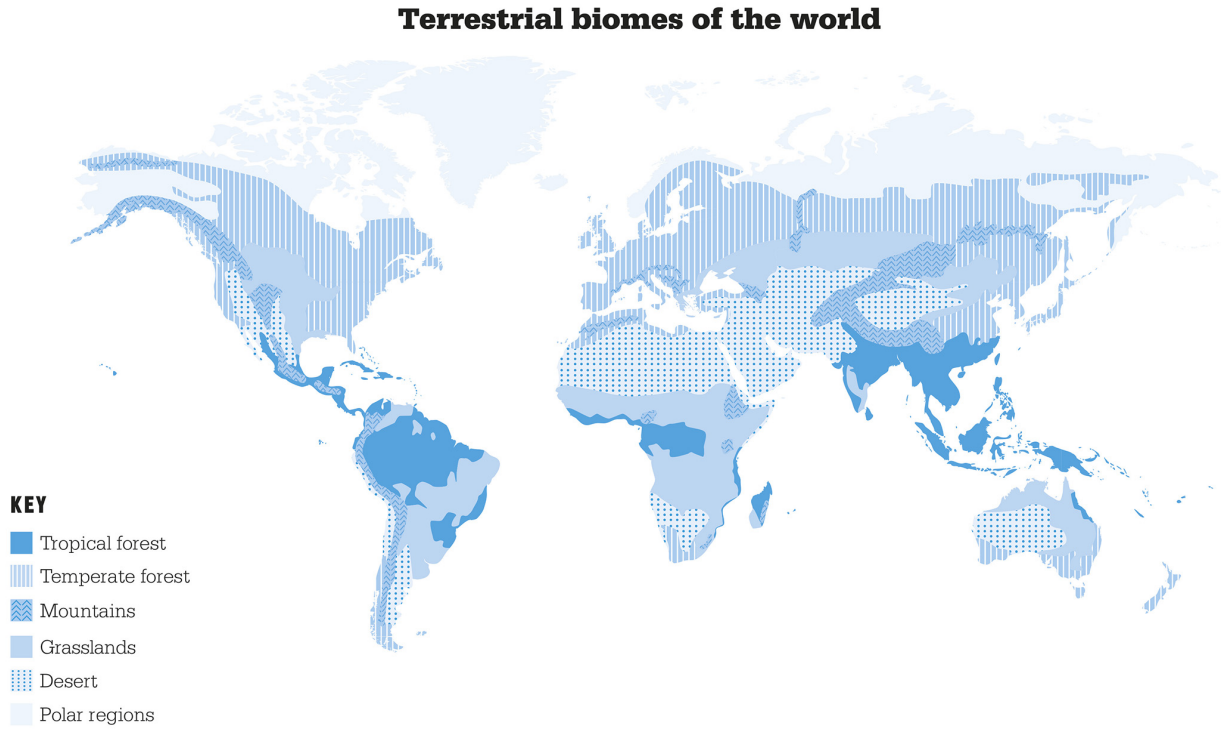
and can survive the harshest frosts. Desert shrubs often have very thin leaves, or no leaves at all, to resist drying out. Biogeographers acknowledge climate's key role when they talk about "tropical" rainforests and "temperate" grasslands.

Very few species have identical climate requirements. Even among varieties of the same plants, there are variations. The sugar maple of eastern North America, for example, is slightly more tolerant of winter cold than its cousin the silver maple. Although the areas where both trees grow overlap, the sugar maple can be seen far over the Canadian border, whereas the silver maple flourishes as far south as Texas. Since biomes give only an approximate picture of plant and animal distribution, ecologists are constantly devising new systems of classification.



This map shows six biomes across the globe. Each area has distinct flora, as major plant types vary from one climatic region to another. Ocean and freshwater biomes are not displayed here, but are equally important to the biosphere.